



Hope Covenant Church Constitution

Contents

1. Introduction	3
2. Name	3
3. Vision.....	3
4. Mission	3
5. Ethos & Character	4
6. What We Believe.....	4
7. Legal Status	9
8. Non-Profit Status.....	9
9. Powers.....	9
10. Structure	9
11. Financial Administration	13
12. Amendments.....	13
13. Disclaimer.....	14
14. Disputes.....	14
15. Dissolution of the church	14
Addendum A: Appointment of a Vocational Elder.....	15
Addendum B: Qualifications of an Elder.....	16
Addendum C: The Ecclesiastical Discipline Process.....	18
Addendum D: The Mercy Policy.....	19
Addendum E: The Mission Policy.....	20
Addendum F: Dispute Resolution	22

1. Introduction

On the 1st of January 2025, Hope Covenant Church was reconstituted as an independent Reformed Congregational Church, following its secession from the Reformed Evangelical Anglican Church of South Africa. This decisive step was taken with solemn conviction and unanimous agreement, as the congregation discerned that the denomination had begun to depart from its original commitment to the supreme authority of God's Word as revealed in the Holy Scriptures.

In reconstituting, the members of Hope Covenant Church sought to remain faithful to the historic Christian gospel and to the principles of the Protestant Reformation, which uphold the sufficiency, clarity, and final authority of Scripture in all matters of faith and life. As an independent Reformed congregation, we affirm the Lordship of Jesus Christ over His Church and the responsibility of each local body to order its life and worship in obedience to His Word.

While we hold firmly to the central truths of Reformed theology—especially those doctrines often referred to as "Calvinistic" — we also recognize that faithful believers may hold differing convictions on the matter of baptism. Within our fellowship, such differences are held in Christian charity and unity, with a shared commitment to the gospel of grace and the authority of Scripture.

This constitution sets forth the convictions, commitments, and structures by which we agree to walk together in faith, love, and obedience to our Lord Jesus Christ. It is not a substitute for Scripture, but a reflection of our shared understanding of how we, as a local church, seek to be governed by it. In all things, our desire is to glorify God, proclaim Christ, and build up His people in truth and love.

Soli Deo Gloria.

2. Name

The independent congregation will be known as **Hope Covenant Church**, hereinafter HCC.

3. Vision

HCC strives to be a biblically grounded church that worships and pleases God, experiencing His presence and blessing in every aspect of church life.

4. Mission

HCC will faithfully persist in...

- a. the DOCTRINE of God's Word,
- b. the CHURCH of the faithful,
- c. the practice of the SACRAMENTS – Baptism and Communion,
- d. PRAYER

- e. PRAISE,
- f. EVANGELISM, and
- g. the giving of financial OFFERINGS,
- h. Assistance to other like-minded churches

... as we look forward to the return of our Lord Jesus Christ.

The above mission statement articulates the seven goals of the congregation.

5. Ethos & Character

HCC holds that, the Bible was and is the only, reliable, sufficient, and non-negotiable norm for learning and living.

We are convinced that the Bible is focused on our Lord Jesus Christ and Him crucified. He is the only way we can worship God, with the help of the Holy Spirit.

We believe in the necessity of rebirth, repentance, sanctification, and perseverance. These responsibilities rest on all people. We also believe that gospel preaching is the power of God through which the Holy Spirit enables us to experience these things.

We at HCC agree with the historical Reformed Christians' beliefs, as laid out in the five Solas, the doctrines of grace, the regulatory principle for worship, the covenant view of God's plan of salvation, and the relevance of the Old Testament law of God to the New Testament believer. We also acknowledge the Heidelberg Catechism, the Belgic Confession, the Savoy Declaration, the Westminster Confession and the 1689 London Confession to be sound summaries of Christian belief.

We are congregational. We place a high premium on the local church as an independent community of true believers.

Due to the diversity of exegetical views on to the mode and time of baptism, "HCC" allows both infant and believers' baptism. Believers who hold either point of view may become members of the congregation, serve in leadership or on the council and enjoy all the privileges of church membership, provided they qualify on all other grounds required for membership and leadership. Members from different points of view are encouraged to lovingly bear with one another.

One party will not try to coerce the other to comply or do that which their consciences do not allow. This does not exclude robust discussion on the topic to be done in a gracious biblical manner in an attempt for both parties to draw closer to the biblical truth of the matter.

6. What We Believe

HCC will strive for unity in the fundamental aspects of the Christian faith and tolerance in the non-fundamental aspects of the Christian faith. We consider the following aspects to be fundamental.

THE CONSTITUTION OF HOPE COVENANT CHURCH

a. About the **Bible**:

We believe that the 66 books of the Bible are the complete Word of God, as originally written, consisting of both the Old and New Testaments. The Bible in its entirety is inspired by the Holy Spirit of God. In its original languages it is flawless. It contains the complete revelation of God to man, and it is the final and supreme authority for all matters pertaining to faith and life. It is sufficient to make the believer wise unto salvation and instructs him to live a holy life. It is the basis of Christian unity.

b. About God:

- i. We believe in one **God**, consisting of three separate yet equal Persons: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. The three Persons of the Godhead are equal in essence and existence, yet different in roles.
- ii. We believe in the absolute and essential divinity of **the Father**, Creator and Sustainer of the Universe; holy; sovereign; eternal; full of love, grace, justice and truth.
- iii. We believe in the absolute and essential divinity of the Son, our Lord Jesus Christ, as one Person with two natures, perfect God and perfect man. We believe in our Lord Jesus Christ's eternal existence with the Father before and after His incarnation; His virgin birth; His sinless life; His vicarious crucifixion; His bodily resurrection from the dead; His triumphant ascension to the right hand of God; His coronation as Ruler over heaven and earth; His ministry as Mediator and High Priest on behalf of believers; and His Second Coming. He is the head of the church which is His body.
- iv. We believe in the absolute and essential divinity of the Holy Spirit, the inalienable gift of God the Father and God the Son to His Church. He is the Person who convicts of sin, righteousness, and judgment. He applies salvation, as planned by the Father and earned by the Son, to every believer. He is the Comforter that permanently lives in all believers.

c. About Satan:

We believe in the existence of Satan as an evil being, the author of sin, and the archenemy of God and man. He is the corruptor of all flesh along with his host of fallen angels.

d. About Humanity:

- i. We believe that God created man in His image as male and female. The Image of God consists of communicated attributes such as love, righteousness and personhood, but does not consist in all that would define God in His infinite glory.
- ii. We believe that mankind's first ancestor, Adam, plunged both himself and his

entire offspring into sin by means of his original sin, and as a result, man died in a physical, spiritual, and moral sense. Along with this, every human being, by birth from Adam, inherits imputed guilt of sin before God and a sinful nature that is completely corrupt.

- iii. We believe that all people, because they are created in the image of God, should be treated with dignity, love and fairness.

e. Concerning **salvation**:

- i. We believe that salvation is a supernatural and sovereign act of God given to those He chose before the foundation of the earth.
- ii. We believe that our Lord Jesus Christ, by virtue of the eternal plan and will of God, lived a life of sinless obedience to the law of God during His earthly ministry, and died a voluntary and vicarious death on the cross, on behalf of every believer, in order to free each of them from punishment, guilt and the power of sin.
- iii. We believe that rebirth is the supernatural and inner work of the Holy Spirit in the heart of all believers thereby making them, who were spiritually dead, spiritually alive and receptive to God.
- iv. We believe that only those who repent of a sinful way of life and put faith in our Lord Jesus Christ will be saved. These are the marks of true conversion.
- v. We believe that justification is the instantaneous and once-off declaration of God of the believer's good standing based solely on faith in our Lord Jesus Christ's all sufficient redemption, and His death and resurrection.
- vi. We believe that sanctification is a lifelong process that begins with rebirth, whereby the Holy Spirit shapes the believer's character into the image of our Lord Jesus Christ. Although the Holy Spirit's work in the sanctification process is primary, the believer has the secondary responsibility to cooperate with the Holy Spirit through obedience to God's Word.
- vii. We believe that everyone who is truly redeemed by the grace of God cannot be lost again but will endure through the power of God in faith until his glorification at the return of our Lord Jesus Christ.

f. About the **future**:

- i. We believe in the personal, bodily, visible and glorious return of our Lord Jesus Christ.
- ii. We believe in the resurrection and judgment of the righteous and the unrighteous.

THE CONSTITUTION OF HOPE COVENANT CHURCH

- iii. We believe in the creation of the new heavens and earth
 - iv. We believe in the eternal bliss of the believer in the new earth and the eternal punishment of the unbeliever in hell.
- g. About the **Church**:
- i. The church is the whole company of those who have been redeemed by Jesus Christ and regenerated by the Holy Spirit.
 - ii. The local church, being a manifestation of the universal church, is a community of believers in a particular place where the Word of God is preached, Baptism, the Lord's Supper and church discipline are practiced, as ordained by God in the Holy Scriptures.
 - iii. The local church is fully autonomous and remains so notwithstanding responsibilities it may accept by voluntary association.
 - iv. We believe in a day of worship and rest as required in the ten commandments. This day is now the first day of the week because of the resurrection of the Lord and the practice of the apostles and New Testament church. This is the day to gather for worship.
 - v. We believe that our Lord Jesus Christ is the supreme Head over the church and that all affairs should be managed according to the Holy Scriptures. This means that all matters of faith and worship are regulated by the scriptures.
 - vi. We believe in the separation of the church and the state in that, in the providence of God, the two differ in their respective nature and functions.
- h. About the **priesthood of all believers**:
- i. We believe that all members of the church have access to God through Jesus Christ.
 - ii. We believe that every believer possesses the freedom to read and interpret the Word of God for himself, according to the precepts of his God-given conscience, as one who possesses the indwelling Spirit of truth. The state and/or any other entity may under no circumstances dictate to the believer what he must believe concerning faith and worship.
 - iii. We believe that all believers are personally responsible and accountable to God for the performance of all religious duties, which are: worship, holy living, evangelism, discipleship and service.

THE CONSTITUTION OF HOPE COVENANT CHURCH

i. About marriage:

- i. We believe that God created marriage as a permanent covenantal relationship between one natural man and one natural woman. It is binding until one of the partners dies.
- ii. It must be recognized by witnesses and a duly established authority.
- iii. Homosexuality and all sexual expressions contrary to God's design in creation are sinful.
- iv. We believe that, although divorce is condemned by the Word of God, there is divorce because of the brokenness of this world. The Word of God specifies two grounds according to which divorce is permissible:
 - a. Adultery
 - b. The malicious abandonment of a spouse, including a mortal threat.

j. Membership

- i. The Membership of HCC consists of believers who voluntarily apply for membership and are examined by the elders and presented to the congregation for admission.
- ii. Members must be at least 18 years old to be eligible to vote.
- iii. After presentation to the congregation, the congregation has a week to raise any objections to the proposed membership of incoming candidates. These objections will be addressed by the Council.
- iv. Members of HCC are required to have a reliable testimony of repentance, a public confession of faith, an acceptance of the word of God and this constitution.
- v. Members of HCC are required to be properly baptized or confirmed in a profession of faith as per this constitution.
- vi. New members may be required to attend a membership course at the discretion of the elders.
- vii. Members of HCC will be expected to contribute to the well-being of the local body in the following ways:
 - a. Regular attendance at the meetings where reasonably possible.
 - b. Serving the other members of the body.
 - c. Upkeep of the facilities according to their abilities.
 - d. Voluntary financial contributions according to their means.

- e. Engagement in outreach and other ministries.
- viii. Termination of church membership will be for the following reasons:
 - a. Resignation
 - b. Transfer of membership to another reputable church body
 - c. Death
 - d. Excommunication
 - e. Unjustified extended absence from meetings

7. Legal Status

- a. HCC is a voluntary, public, and non-profit organization with an autonomous identity and legal status that is independent of its members and exists for the sake of fulfilling its goals until dissolved in accordance with the stipulations of this Constitution
- b. HCC shall enjoy the benefits and liability of any commercial and/or legal action undertaken by her delegated representative/s for the specific responsibilities assigned.
- c. HCC will operate according to the laws of the Republic of South Africa, provided that these laws do not conflict with any biblical teachings, principles, or commands.

8. Non-Profit Status

- a. HCC is registered as a Non-profit company (NPC) under the name of Gospel Hope Foundation.
- b. All income, which includes tithes, collections, donations and bequests, as well as assets, which include movable and non-movable property, will be used exclusively for the fulfilment of the mission of HCC as stipulated in this constitution.
- c. No member can claim personal benefit and/or material enrichment from their membership at HCC, except for the payment of reasonable salaries or salary packages to the church's employees.
- d. The non-movable property of HCC, however acquired, will be registered in the name of HOPE COVENANT CHURCH, unless otherwise agreed and ratified by a congregational meeting.

9. Powers

HCC shall possess the right to buy, sell, donate, rent, lease, exchange, transfer, receive in terms of donations or other movable or non-movable property, to invest funds, to open bank accounts, to create, to withdraw, to accept, to give discounts and to release any assets.

10. Structure

According to the scriptures, The Lord Jesus has appointed two offices for church administration, namely: Male elders and male deacons.

THE CONSTITUTION OF HOPE COVENANT CHURCH

Their duties are as follows:

- a. Elders are responsible for
 - i. The spiritual well-being of the congregation through teaching, preaching and administering of the sacraments.
 - ii. Pastoral care involving visitation, counselling and prayer.
 - iii. Oversight of Church disciplinary procedures.
 - iv. The protection and warning of the congregation against false teaching
 - v. General leadership and oversight of all church ministries.
 - vi. Administering membership applications.
 - vii. Leading church meetings.

HCC will strive to uphold the biblical principle of a plurality of elders and we believe in the parity of these elders. We recognize that at least one elder is called to full-time vocational ministry in the church and will receive remuneration from the congregation. He may, when the need arises, do part-time work to supplement his income, with the agreement of the other elders.

The elders of HCC will meet at least once per month to fulfill their obligations. Minutes will be taken.

A remunerated full-time elder will be re-confirmed every five years at the AGM by a 70% yes vote by secret ballot.

A Lay elder will re-confirm every 3 years at the AGM by a 70% yes vote by secret ballot.

- b. Deacons are responsible for
 - i. The temporal affairs relating to the day-to-day running of the church.
 - ii. Attending to the benevolent care of the church members and adherents.

HCC will strive to uphold the biblical principle of a plurality of deacons, as far as possible.

The deacons of HCC will meet at least once per month to fulfill their obligations. Minutes will be taken.

Deacons will be reconfirmed every year at the AGM by secret ballot.

c. Appointment of Office bearers

- i. Regarding the appointment of office bearers, the elders will request nominations from the membership.
- ii. All nominations will be vetted by the elders in light of God's Word.
- iii. Suitable candidates will then be presented to the congregation.
- iv. The membership will be given a minimum of three weeks' opportunity to lodge objections against the candidate/s.
- v. The elders reserve the right to extend this period.
- vi. If the congregation submits a valid objection that disqualifies the candidate, the elders will inform the congregation that the candidate cannot be ordained to the office in question.
- vii. If the congregation does not submit any objections that disqualifies the candidate, he will be presented for ratification by ballot at the next AGM.
- viii. He will be consecrated at the following Communion service.
- ix. All newly appointed office bearers, serving for the first time in office, must undergo a period of training or instruction subject to the discretion and direction of the existing leadership, to be properly equipped for effective service to the congregation.
- x. Healthy communication between elders, deacons and all other stakeholders will be pursued continuously, to raise awareness of the spiritual and practical needs of the congregation, as well as to coordinate the care of such needs.

d. Authority

- i. The Office bearers may, from time to time, designate an individual/s or a working group/s to perform specific tasks, in the areas of their expertise, under the responsibility of the elders.
- ii. Deacons will have the authority to decide on financial commitments up to the budgets established by the congregation without consulting the elders. They will accurately account for all expenditure to the congregation at least once a year.
- iii. The elders reserve the right to terminate the service of individuals and work groups so designated at any time.

e. Removal of Office Bearers

- i. Any accusation of misconduct, heresy or unsuitability that is leveled at an office bearer must be investigated by the eldership as to the validity of the accusation.
- ii. If the accusation is found to be ungrounded, then the matter needs to be laid aside, and if it was public knowledge then the congregation needs to be informed.
- iii. If the accusation has merit, then the following steps need to be implemented:
 - The person needs to be suspended from office.
 - An in-depth investigation needs to be conducted with the evidence of the available witnesses.
 - Should the investigation show that the accusations are unfounded then the person must be acquitted and reinstated, if the matter was public then he must be publicly acquitted.
 - The person bringing the accusation needs to be admonished to be more cautious in the bringing of an accusation.
 - If the investigation shows that the person is indeed guilty of the accusation and thus discredited himself from the position, then that person needs to be removed from the office, and the congregation needs to be informed wisely and lovingly.

Congregational Meetings

The Congregation is mandated to hold an Annual General meeting every year. This will take place in early May after the financial year end (end of February each year). Reports will be given on the finances and all the ministries and activities of the church for the past year.

Other general meetings will be held whenever necessary. These will be called according to the procedure as laid out below.

1. A general meeting is considered constitutional if a quorum of 70% of the voting members are present. Only voting members will enjoy the right to vote at general meetings. A simple majority vote (50% of the quorum + 1) will determine a decision, unless otherwise provided by this Constitution.
2. Notice of general meetings along with the agenda will be announced by the eldership at least two Sundays before the date. The elders reserve the right to extend this period.
3. General meetings will not be held during school holidays, long weekends or on public holidays.
4. An elder, or in the absence of an elder a suitable person designated by the congregation, will preside over the general meeting.
5. A verbal vote or showing of hands will be appropriate for all matters on the agenda of the general meeting. Based on the recommendation of the chairman or any member, a secret ballot may be used in the case of sensitive matters to determine the decision.
6. The minutes of all general meetings will be taken and preserved for future reference.

THE CONSTITUTION OF HOPE COVENANT CHURCH

7. Minutes of general meetings and copies of essential documentation will be made available to any member on request.
8. Disclosure of confidential personal circumstances and private matters will only occur following appropriate discussions and approval, in compliance with the Protection of Personal Information Act (POPIA). It is our legal obligation to safeguard this information, and we are committed to transparent communication with the church community regarding any necessary disclosures.
9. At least twice a year, HCC will meet for a report meeting, during which feedback will be given on the congregation's financial well-being and any other matter affecting the well-being of the congregation, subject to elders' discretion.
10. An elder of HCC, or an appointed representative, shall serve as the public spokesperson for HCC as necessary.
11. In the case of a grievance that has nothing to do with a sin issue, the grievance procedure attached as Addendum B at the end of this Constitution must be followed.

11. Financial Administration

- a. The elders of HCC are responsible for overseeing HCC's finances according to biblical principles. For this purpose, they may co-opt competent help from outside the congregation or appoint a treasurer from the membership of the congregation under their supervision. In the case where this is done, the co-opted auxiliary or appointed treasurer will function under the supervision of the elders.
- b. HCC will pay reasonable salaries or salary packages to its employees.
- c. HCC will maintain an updated and auditable financial accounting system for all income and expenses, so that feedback can be given to the elders, any member/s, or at a congregational report meeting on request.
- d. Finances will be submitted annually for an independent review by a registered accounting person or institution.
- e. The financial year will run from the first day of March to the last day of February.
- f. All financial documentation will be signed by at least two signatories as determined by the elders.
- g. Immediately following worship services, offerings will be counted, recorded on a record sheet, and signed by an office bearer in the presence of at least one other trusted individual. Under no circumstances should this process be conducted by a single person. All collected offerings will be deposited into HCC's bank account on a monthly basis by an office bearer or a designated trusted delegate.

12. Amendments

- a. Any member/s of HCC may at any time propose amendments to this Constitution as necessary to facilitate its administration. Such suggestions should be put in writing and addressed to the elders.

- b. Amendments to this constitution require prior approval from the elders and a favorable vote from 80% of members present at a general meeting. If a proposed amendment is rejected, it may still be adopted with revisions.
- c. No proposed amendments shall in any way contradict any other provision/s of this Constitution.

13. Disclaimer

Any member of HCC acting as a delegate of the congregation shall enjoy full indemnity against all actions, costs, penalties, losses, damages and expenses for which they may be held liable, collectively or individually, in the performance of the duties for which they are delegated; except in the case of blatant negligence or unlawful conduct, which includes violating any provision of this Constitution.

14. Disputes

In the unlikely event where a dispute arises which the elders and/or the congregation cannot resolve, and which jeopardizes the well-being of HCC, the elders will refer the dispute to the committee of independent persons as established according to Addendum F to objectively arbitrate and settle the dispute.

15. Dissolution of the church

- a. HCC may be dissolved at any time by means of an 80% majority vote of voting members at a general meeting. The result of this meeting will be forwarded to the last known contact of all the current members.
- b. The elders will involve an ecclesiastical council external to the congregation, as appointed in addendum F to consult in the dissolution process.
- c. If a quorum of voting members, as indicated on HCC's membership role, is not present at the above general meeting, the members present must postpone the vote regarding the dissolution of HCC for a minimum of two weeks. All members must be informed of the date of the follow-up meeting. At this follow-up general meeting, the voting members present will form a quorum.
- d. The voting members at the above general meeting, will decide how the assets, movable and immovable, will be disposed. This transfer will finalize the dissolution of HCC.

Addendum A: Appointment of a Vocational Elder

The appointment of a vocational elder will take place as follows:

1. The council may co-opt church members to assist them in the selection of a new pastor. This 'call committee' will prayerfully identify candidates that qualify for the position and that are available to receive a call.
2. The call committee must do the necessary due diligence, scrutiny and examination.
3. The call committee of HCC will prayerfully reflect and decide on an appropriate salary package within the financial capacity of the congregation.
4. The call committee of HCC may get advice from leadership from other churches to assist in the appointment process.
5. A candidate must meet the qualifications of an elder as specified in addendum B, in addition he must:
 - a. Have a theological qualification from a recognized theological institution, or have adequate prior, learning and experience
 - b. Be properly fluent in the English language.
 - c. Be able to preach and teach on a continuous basis on all of scripture.
 - d. Be able to counsel biblically and personally.
 - e. Have relevant pastoral ministry experience, unless exempted by exceptional gifts or circumstances.
6. The 'call committee' of HCC will invite candidates who qualify according to the above point 5 for an interview/s and ministry opportunity during a worship service.
7. At the conclusion of the interviews and ministries with the candidates who qualify, the "call committee' will prayerfully reflect over a period of not less than two weeks. If there is consensus among the elders on the 'call committee', they may proceed to the next step of the calling process. If there is no consensus, step (6) of the calling process must be repeated until consensus is reached.
8. The elders will then present the candidate to the congregation. The membership will be given opportunity to discuss the candidate and raise any objections. If no disqualifying objections are raised, the congregation will proceed to vote.
9. A majority vote of 75% of all voting members present at a constituted general meeting is required to be able to employ the candidate.
10. If the candidate does not meet the approval of the church, the "call committee" will return to the calling process.
11. The Council will issue a letter of appointment and contract of employment to the prospective candidate and upon his acceptance, he will become the new vocational elder.
12. Any expenses incurred during the calling process, which are fair and necessary for its success, will be the responsibility of HCC.

Addendum B: Qualifications of an Elder

The qualifications of an elder according to the Scriptures are as follows:

1. Must be a man (1 Timothy 2:11-12; 3:2; 1 Corinthians 14:34-38).
2. Must be blameless in character (1 Timothy 3:2-3; Titus 1:6-8).
3. Must be gifted to teach (1 Timothy 3:2; Titus 1:9).
4. Must manage his household well (1 Timothy 3:4-5).
5. Must be a faithful husband to one wife (1 Tim 3:2)
6. Must be spiritually and emotionally mature (1 Timothy 3:6).
7. Must maintain a good witness (1 Timothy 3:7; 4:12).
8. Be reformed in his theological beliefs.

HCC regards being “reformed” as follows:

He must hold generally to one or more of the confessions as stated in **Point 6. Ethos and Character** of the church. He needs to sign a formal document to this regard.

Duties of an Elder

The elders of the local congregation are responsible for shepherding the congregation under the authority of the Supreme Pastor, our Lord Jesus Christ, to ensure her spiritual and temporal well-being. They will do this in the following ways:

1. Prayer (Acts 6:4; James 5:14)
2. Ministry of the Word (Acts 6:4, Acts 20:2, 1Tim 3:2,15; 5:17)
3. Counselling Guidance (Tit 1:9)
4. Self-examination (Acts 20:28a; 1Tim.3:4-5; 4:16)
5. Equipping (2 Tim 2:2)
6. Protection (1 Pet.5:2 & 8, Titus 1:9, Acts 20: 28 & 29)
7. Ruling of the Church (Heb 13:7, 1 Tim 5:17)
8. Overseeing worship, sacraments, all ministries and special services (2 Tim 4:5, Eph 4:11-13)

Qualifications of a Deacon

The qualifications of a deacon according to the Scriptures are as follows:

1. Godly Character (1 Tim 3:8)
2. Honest (1 Tim 3:8)
3. Faithful family man (1 Tim 3:12)
4. Not a lover of Money (1 Tim 3: 3&8)
5. Good reputation in the church and community (1 Tim 3: 13)
6. Have the ability, willingness and the time to service (1 Tim 3:13)
7. Must hold to the doctrines of HCC as laid out in Point 7 above

Duties of a Deacon

The deacons must support the elders by taking responsibility for the practical needs of the congregation and church life to free them to focus on prayer and the ministry of the Word. The deacons may engage people according to their wise judgment to assist them in this service. They will be responsible, amongst others, for the following:

1. Repairs and maintenance, (toilets, security, electricity, and safety)
2. Sound and projection
3. Foyer duties (rosters and quality control)
4. Finances
5. Tea and coffee
6. Rental of church facilities to other parties
7. Building and grounds management
8. Transport
9. Benevolence

Addendum C: The Ecclesiastical Discipline Process

According to the teaching of our Lord Jesus Christ in Matthew 18:15-17, members who persist in unrepentant sin are to be dealt with according to the following process:

- STEP 1: The onus rests on the member who becomes aware of a fellow member/s' sin/s, to confront them in private, to persuade them to repent of their sin and restore them to effective service in God's kingdom. If they respond positively to this admonition, with genuine repentance, the matter is then settled. If the person refuses to repent, the matter will proceed to step 2.
- STEP 2: The matter must be brought to the elders of HCC and a delegation of two or three will confront the accused with their sin with the goal of repentance and restoration. If they respond positively to this admonition, with genuine repentance, the matter is then settled. If the person refuses to repent, membership privileges will be suspended and the matter will proceed to step 3
- STEP 3: The elders will inform those who persist in unrepentant sin of their biblical mandate, and intention to bring the matter before the congregation. After this, the elders will tell the congregation and call on them to pray and confront them about their sin, to persuade them to repentance and restoration. Membership privileges will continue to be suspended if no repentance is evident. If they respond positively to this admonition, with genuine repentance, the matter is then settled, and after a period, membership privileges can be restored. If the person refuses to repent, the matter will proceed to step 4.
- STEP 4: The congregation will meet to excommunicate the impenitent member. The elders will inform the offending member/s verbally and in writing, of the congregation's decision to excommunicate with immediate effect. The elders must explain to the congregation what excommunication entails. (Matt 18:17, 2Thes 3:14, 1Cor 5: 3-6). The member's name will be removed from the membership list.
- The congregation must be willing to restore the erring member back into fellowship if they repent and seek forgiveness. (2 Cor 2: 6-9)

Addendum D: The Mercy Policy

According to biblical precept (1 John 3:16-18) and example (Acts 4:34-35), HCC will provide mercy aid to her members who lack basic means of subsistence (James 2:14-17). The membership is encouraged to bring temporary needs within the congregation to the attention of the deacons.

Mercy assistance will be applied first to members of the congregation as church resources allow.

The deacons will be allocated a monthly allowance for benevolence at the AGM.

The deacons must report on the spending at the council meeting each month.

Special donations and benevolence over and above the deacons' monthly allowance, must be decided by the council.

All budgets to be allocated by the congregation at the AGM.

The following biblical principles will apply

1. The elders must investigate any abnormal or excessive use of the benevolence by members of the congregation and adherents. Deacons must report any suspicious use of benevolence to the elders. (Acts 4: 34-35)

Benevolence is subject to the following conditions:

- a. If the member or members do not have family members who are part of the congregation and can offer help (1 Timothy 5:3-4, 8, 16, Deuteronomy 15:7-8) they should be requested to take up their "duty" in order not to "burden" the congregation.
 - b. If the member(s) do not live extravagantly (1 Tim.5:5-6).
 - c. If the member(s) cannot take care of themselves. (1 Timothy 5:9a).
 - d. If the member(s) maintain a reputation for devotion and good works. (1 Tim.5:9b-10).
 - e. Long-term benevolence must be investigated every 3 months to control dependency on congregational funds.
 - f. The council reserves the right to render assistance as they see fit. (Direct payment of bills, grocery purchases or contributions, meals by the congregation and other relevant assistance)
2. The council may, in exceptional cases, render assistance to individuals who are not members of the congregation; provided the congregation's financial well-being allows it, and it is within the budgetary allowance given by the congregation. ALL spending by the council will be reported in detail to the congregation at the AGM.
 3. The council reserves the right to terminate any mercy assistance at any time.

Addendum E: The Mission Policy

Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to establish guidelines for the support and selection of missionaries by HCC, ensuring that our efforts align with our mission and values as an independent church.

It is the duty and privilege of every follower of Christ and of every church of the Lord Jesus Christ to endeavor to make disciples of all nations. The new birth of man's spirit by God's Holy Spirit means the birth of love for others. Missionary effort on the part of all rests thus upon a spiritual necessity of the regenerate life and is expressly and repeatedly commanded in the teachings of Christ. The Lord Jesus Christ has commanded the preaching of the gospel to all nations. It is the duty of every child of God to seek constantly to win the lost to Christ by verbal witness undergirded by a Christian lifestyle, and by other methods in harmony with the gospel of Christ.

Genesis 12:1-3; Exodus 19:5-6; Isaiah 6:1-8; Matthew 9:37-38; 10:5-15; 13:18-30, 37-43; 16:19; 22:9-10; 24:14; 28:18-20; Luke 10:1-18; 24:46-53; John 14:11-12; 15:7-8,16; 17:15; 20:21; Acts 1:8; 2; 8:26-40; 10:42-48; 13:2-3; Romans 10:13-15; Ephesians 3:1-11; 1 Thessalonians 1:8; 2 Timothy 4:5; Hebrews 2:1-3; 11:39-12:2; 1 Peter 2:4-10; Revelation 22:17.

Missionary Support

1. Definition of Support

Support may include financial contributions, prayer, training, and logistical assistance for individuals or organizations engaged in missionary work.

2. Budgeting for Missions

The church shall allocate a specific percentage of its annual budget to missionary support, ensuring transparency and accountability in financial stewardship.

3. Types of Support

We may provide:

- Monthly financial support
- One-time gifts for specific projects or needs
- In-kind donations (e.g., supplies, resources)
- Prayer support and encouragement

Selection of Missionaries

1. Criteria for Selection

Missionaries must:

- Be a member of a protestant church approved by the Elders.
- Demonstrate a commitment to the Christian faith and the mission of the church.
- Present a clear vision and strategy for their missionary work.

- Exhibit a track record of effective ministry or service, including references from their sending church or organization.

2. **Application Process**

Potential missionaries must communicate with HCC:

- A personal testimony of faith
- Details of their missionary calling and work
- Financial needs and budget
- Record of support (provided by sending org)
- References from spiritual leaders or mentors

3. **Evaluation Committee**

An evaluation committee, composed of church leaders and members, will review all applications. This committee will assess candidates based on the established criteria and may conduct interviews to gain further insight into the applicants' vision and ministry.

4. **Approval Process**

After evaluation, the committee will present recommendations to the church leadership for approval. Final decisions will be made by the church board, ensuring alignment with our mission and values.

5. **Ongoing Accountability**

Supported missionaries will be required to provide regular updates on their ministry, including financial reports and prayer requests. This will help ensure accountability and strengthen the relationship between the church and the missionaries.

Conclusion

Through this policy, HCC aims to faithfully support those called to missionary work, fostering a spirit of partnership, prayer, and mutual encouragement as we strive to fulfill the Great Commission.

Addendum F: Dispute Resolution

In the pursuit of good governance, unity, and peace within the local church—and in recognition that the Evil One continually seeks to sow disorder, discontent, and division among the saints—it is deemed wise to establish a biblically faithful process for resolving significant conflict. While the ideal is that a congregation, along with its elders and deacons, should seek the wisdom of God in His Word and the peace of the Holy Spirit in resolving all matters of unrest, there may be exceptional occasions when internal efforts reach an impasse. In such situations, a mechanism is needed to guide the church toward resolution in a manner consistent with Scripture and historic Reformed principles.

The following quote from the **1689 Second London Baptist Confession of Faith**, Chapter 26, paragraph 15, affirms the biblical prudence of external advisory involvement in difficult cases:

“In cases of difficulties or differences, either in point of doctrine or administration, wherein either the churches in general are concerned, or any one church, in their peace, union, and edification; or any member or members of any church are injured, in or by any proceedings in censures not agreeable to truth and order: it is according to the mind of Christ, that many churches holding communion together, do, by their messengers, meet to consider, and give their advice in or about that matter in difference, to be reported to all the churches concerned; howbeit these messengers assembled, are not entrusted with any church-power properly so called; or with any jurisdiction over the churches themselves...”

Consistent with this Confession and our understanding of the autonomy of the local church, such external assistance must function in an advisory capacity only. These messengers cannot exercise ecclesiastical authority over a local church but may provide valuable mediation and guidance.

To this end, the church shall establish a Resolution Committee, composed of trusted, godly, and mature elders from like-minded congregations, to assist in mediating and resolving significant disputes when internal resolution proves ineffective (cf. 2 Cor. 1:24).

1) Appointment of Potential Committee Members

At a duly convened General Church Meeting every two years, the Church shall identify and approve six pastors or elders, ideally one from each of six like-minded congregations, who may serve on an ad hoc Resolution Committee should a need arise.

- a) Prior to their approval, consent must be obtained from each nominee.
- b) These individuals are to be informed that they may, at their discretion, make pastoral enquiries concerning the state of the church and its leadership, with a view to supporting spiritual health.
- c) The names of the six approved individuals shall be recorded in the official minutes of the meeting.

2) Function and Formation of the Resolution Committee

- a) Purpose
The Resolution Committee may be convened to address unresolved disputes within the church that, in the judgment of the Pastor, the Eldership, the Church Council, or the Membership, are:
 - i) Negatively affecting the church’s ministry or,

- ii) Seriously threatening the unity and peace of the church.

b) Scope of Disputes

The Committee may be called upon in the following cases:

- i) Between a group(s) of members and the remainder of the church membership.
- ii) Between the Pastor and the entire congregation or a faction thereof.
- iii) Between the Pastor and the Eldership or Diaconate.
- iv) Between the Elders and the church membership.
- v) Between the Elders and the Deacons.
- vi) Between one Elder and another Elder.

c) Activation of the Committee

- i) The Committee may be convened by a decision of the Eldership or by resolution of the Church at a duly convened General Meeting.
- ii) Upon activation, the Elders shall nominate three individuals from the pool of six pre-approved candidates to constitute the Resolution Committee.
- iii) These three shall appoint a Chairperson from among themselves.

d) Authority and Process

- i) The Resolution Committee shall function in an advisory and mediatory capacity only.
- ii) The Committee may attend relevant meetings, with the Chairperson presiding where appropriate.
- iii) After investigating and mediating the matter, the Committee shall submit a written report to be included in the minutes of the next General Church Meeting.

e) Outcome and Implementation

- i) If a resolution is reached, the report shall summarize the outcome.
- ii) If no resolution is achieved, the report shall include recommendations, which must be submitted to the church at a General Meeting and subjected to a congregational vote.
- iii) Upon acceptance, the Eldership shall be responsible for implementing the recommendations within three (3) months.

f) Financial Responsibility

- i) The Church shall be liable for the reasonable expenses incurred by members of the Resolution Committee.

g) Pastoral Priority

- i) Notwithstanding the above, the Eldership shall take all reasonable steps to promote reconciliation and unity within the church, in accordance with Scripture (e.g., Matt. 5:23–24; Rom. 12:18; Eph. 4:1–3).